Optional CFD practice: subcritical airfoil response

Purpose and submission

This open-tool practice exercise prepares you for the in-class CFD interpretation practical. You may work alone or with others and may use the repository documentation, AI tools, notes, and any other resources. You are not being assessed on independent coding.

You may submit the completed evidence sheet for small extra credit and feedback. Feedback addresses whether your claims are supported by your figures and data; it is not a grade for prose or authorship.

What to run

Run `python course/build_week1_subcritical_figures.py` from the repository root. It generates a NACA 2412 geometry, a lift/drag polar from an incidence sweep, and a surface-pressure plot at one subcritical operating point. Do not alter the solver unless you wish to explore beyond the exercise.

Reference relations

For this simplified screening exercise, the two-dimensional airfoil coefficients are treated as representative wing coefficients:

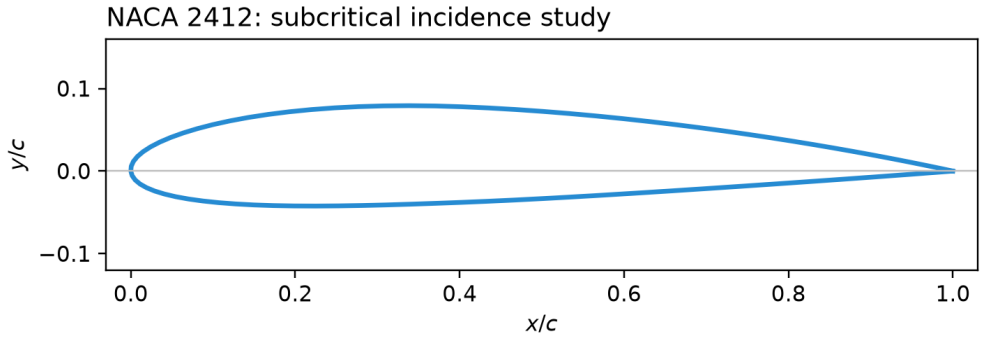
$$L = q_\infty S C_L, \qquad D = q_\infty S C_D, \qquad q_\infty = \tfrac{1}{2}\rho_\infty V_\infty^2.$$

For this practice study, hold $M_\infty = 0.50$ fixed and vary only incidence α. This is intentionally a subcritical study: no shock constraint or transonic design decision is part of Week 1.

Model boundary. This is a two-dimensional inviscid calculation. It is useful for identifying trends in pressure loading and lift, but it does not predict skin-friction drag, separation, three-dimensional effects, structural loads, or aircraft performance.

A. Generate and inspect the incidence sweep

The supplied script evaluates one NACA 2412 section over several angles of attack. Record the output values from your run. If you submit this page, attach the polar and the $\alpha = 2^\circ$ surface-pressure plot.



Incidence α	C_L	C_D	Lift trend	Drag trend	Evidence used	Comment
-2°						
2°						
6°						

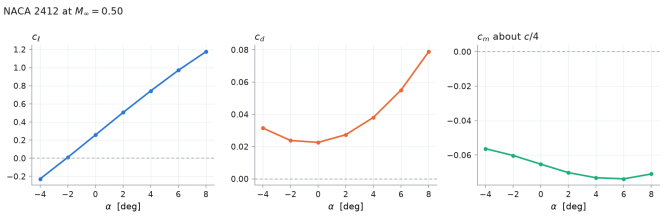
1. On the $\alpha = 2^\circ$ pressure plot, identify the upper and lower surfaces. State which surface has the lower pressure over most of the chord.

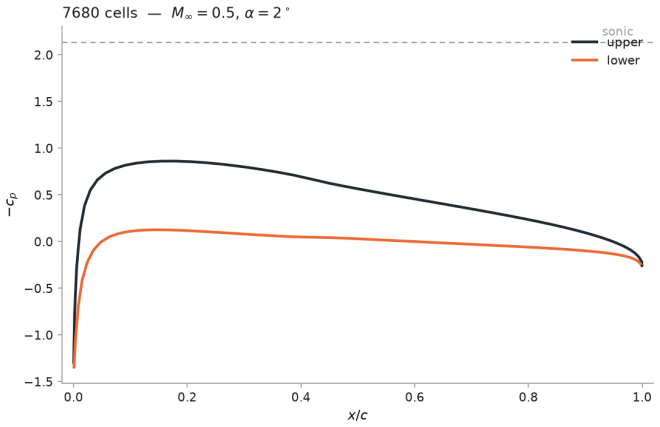
2. Using your polar, describe the trend of C_L as α increases. Do not call the trend "proof" of a real-airfoil performance limit.

3. Identify one conclusion that this inviscid, subcritical exercise cannot support.

B. Compare output types

The Week 1 figures answer different questions: the polar summarizes integrated loads over incidence, while the C_p curve shows where the pressure loading comes from. This is a response study, not an optimization map.





4. Explain why a polar alone cannot tell you where on the airfoil the pressure loading changed.

5. Explain why one C_p curve alone cannot tell you how the integrated lift changes over the full incidence range.

6. Predict what you expect to happen to the upper-surface pressure distribution if α is increased from 2° to 6°. State the observation you would inspect to check that prediction.